

Is a Psychology Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The already-in-it guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, and what to do from where you already are.

3.5

AI EXPOSURE · CLINICAL PSYCHOLOGIST (LICENSED)
where 10 is most at risk

For anyone already in it — in the degree, or job-hunting.



Before you read this

The choice is already made — you're in a psychology degree or training, or out of one and into the job hunt. So this guide skips the "should you study psychology" question and goes straight to the one that's actually live: given where you already are, what do you do about it?

It's written to you directly — whether you are the one in it, or a parent reading on their behalf. Where it says "you," a parent can simply read "them"; the moves are the same either way.

What this is. A facts document, not a pep talk. It sets out what's known about where psychology sits in an AI economy, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then what to actually do from here.

The good news, up front. Already in it is not too late — not close. Psychology isn't one destination, it's a wide spread of them, from 3.5 to 7.1, and almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Where you land inside that range is decided mostly by moves still in front of you — chiefly, whether you steer toward the license. The second half of this guide is those moves.

And one thing specific to psychology. This is the field where the headline number is most misleading, in both directions. Licensed clinical practice is among the safest careers we measure; a psychology degree on its own is among the more exposed. The entire question now lives in the gap between those two, and that gap is about commitment to a long path rather than about AI. The good news is that the gap is crossed by moves, and the moves are still available to you.

The short answer

The licensed path is excellent. Most psychology graduates never reach it.

A licensed clinical psychologist scores 3.5 out of 10. A psychology degree with no further qualification scores 7.1.

That 3.6-point spread is the largest gap in this index between destinations reached from a single degree. Nothing else we score varies this much depending on what a graduate does next.

And the number that should frame everything below: only about 14% of psychology bachelor's holders go on to graduate study in psychology. Which rung of that spread you reach is decided

mostly by what you do from here.

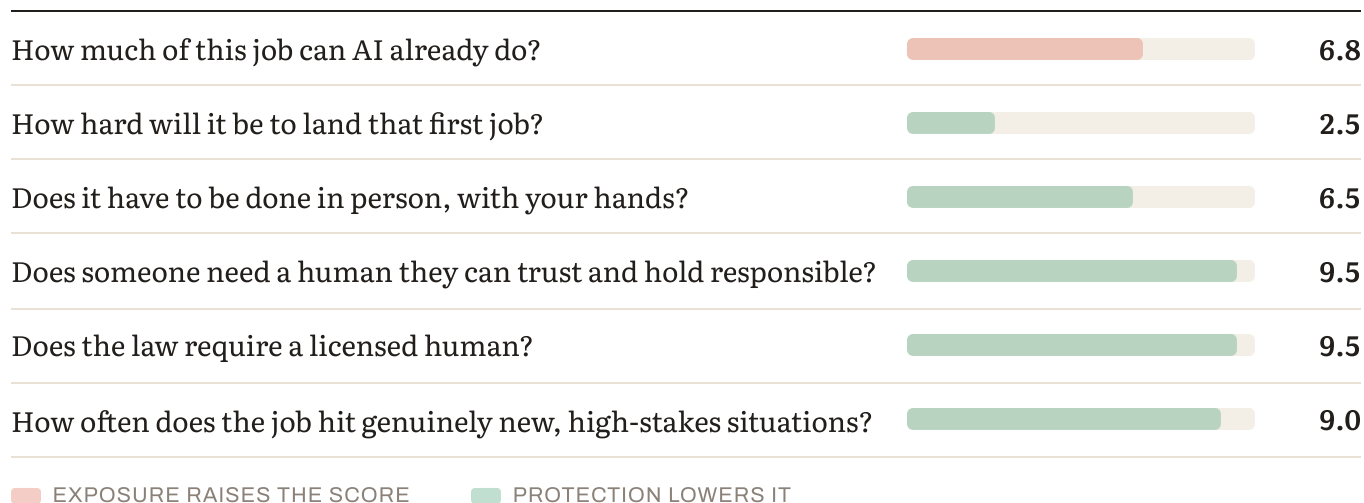
The scores

DESTINATION	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Clinical psychologist (licensed)	2.8	3.2	3.5	+0.7	Low
Counselor / psychotherapist (licensed)	3.2	3.5	3.9	+0.7	Low
School psychologist	3.2	3.6	4.0	+0.8	Low–Moderate
Research / academic psychology	5.4	5.9	6.5	+1.1	Moderate– High
Organizational / HR-adjacent roles	5.9	6.5	7.0	+1.1	High
Degree only, no further qualification	6.1	6.6	7.1	+1.0	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession sits around 5.5, bedside nursing scores 2.8, classroom teaching 3.6, and entry-level software development 8.1.

Read the table this way: the top three rows all require a license. The bottom three do not. The license is doing essentially all of the protective work. Your job, from here, is to move up the table toward it — not to hope the table moves.

Why the licensed path scores low — the six factors



Here's how a licensed clinical psychologist answers them. Knowing *why* the licensed path holds at 3.5 while the degree alone sits at 7.1 is what tells you which way to move.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

A surprising amount of the surrounding work — and almost none of the therapy.

Session notes and documentation. Intake screening and scheduling. Progress tracking and outcome measures. Psychoeducational material. Standardized assessment scoring.

What does not automate: the therapeutic relationship, sitting with someone in genuine distress, judgment when a client is at risk, and legal accountability for a patient's safety.

We rate this 6.8 — higher than people expect. A great deal of what fills a clinician's week is automatable. **It simply isn't the part that matters.**

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Once licensed, easy. Getting licensed is the filter.

Licensed clinical and counseling roles show unemployment as low as 1.3%, against roughly 2.5% for graduates generally. Demand comfortably exceeds supply and has for years.

But this factor measures the route in, and psychology's route is long: graduate study plus supervised practice hours, typically **six to eight years** in total. **Much of that period is low-paid or unpaid, which is a financial filter rather than an academic one.**

The way through isn't to shortcut the license — there isn't a shortcut — it's to enter the pipeline that leads to it deliberately. Assistant and support-worker experience is the bottleneck for graduate applications, so securing it is where your effort compounds. Research

methods and statistics are what separate a psychology graduate from someone who has only read about psychology, and they are the spine of a competitive application. And for anyone drawn to the clinical work rather than the discipline, a shorter licensed route exists — mental health nursing reaches licensed practice in three to four years and scores 2.8. Those are concrete moves, not a hope, and the career-hunting checklist later in this guide lays them out.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

Moderately — and less than most people assume.

Therapy is increasingly delivered remotely, and that works clinically. So psychology has less physical protection than nursing or medicine. It compensates elsewhere.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

This is the highest rating we give any career in this index, and the section on the trust factor explains why.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

Comprehensively — and, unusually, the law is currently moving toward the profession rather than away from it.

Several US states have moved to prohibit AI systems from delivering licensed therapy. This is one of very few places in this index where regulation is being written to protect a profession rather than quietly eroding around it.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

Constantly. Every client is a different history, and risk judgments carry consequences that cannot be undone. The distance between a licensed clinician making those calls and a general graduate who never will is the distance you're trying to close.

The trust factor — and the limit of what it protects

We give psychology 9.5 on human trust and accountability. That's the highest rating on any factor for any career in this index, and it deserves explaining — because understanding what it protects also reveals what it doesn't.

Two things sit inside this factor. Trust: does the work require a person present in a way another person can rely on? Accountability: must a human own the outcome when something goes wrong?

Therapy scores at the top of both, and for a reason that has no parallel elsewhere in this index. In most professions the relationship is a delivery mechanism for the service. In therapy the relationship is the treatment. A surgeon's patient wants competence. A therapy client needs to be known by someone. And when a client is at risk of harm, a licensed human carries duty-of-care obligations no system can hold.

But notice precisely what this protects.

It protects the *practice* — the requirement that a licensed human performs the work. It does not protect the *volume* of that work.

"Therapy and companionship" is now among the most common uses of general-purpose AI. A substantial share of young people report using chatbots for emotional support, mostly without telling anyone. None of that competes with a licensed therapist under the same rules — it isn't therapy, it isn't regulated, and it carries no accountability. But it may, over time, change how many people seek professional help at all.

Our framework measures whether a human must do the work. It cannot measure how many humans are needed.

That is the single clearest gap in our methodology, and psychology is where it shows. We'd rather name it than let a reassuring score do work it hasn't earned. A profession can be legally protected and still shrink.

What we're watching: whether referral volumes and waiting lists move in either direction over the next few editions. If demand for professional care falls while the license holds, our score is measuring the wrong thing and we'll say so.

What the trend shows

Licensed clinical: 2.8 → 3.2 → 3.5. Up 0.7 points, and nearly all of it documentation.

Degree only: 6.1 → 6.6 → 7.1. Up 1.0.

The gap has widened from 3.3 points to 3.6. Both ends are drifting, and the unlicensed end faster — for the same reason business is drifting. Without a license, a psychology graduate enters the general graduate market and carries whatever exposure that market carries.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Highest in the index	Durable	The relationship is the treatment. Socially and legally rooted.
Regulatory / licensing	Very strong	Most durable, and strengthening	Several states are actively legislating to reserve therapy to licensed humans.
Judgment under novelty	Strong	Eroding slowly	Risk assessment and formulation are not automating meaningfully.
Physical / embodied	Moderate	Weakest here	Remote delivery already works, so there is less physical protection than in nursing or medicine.

The honest read. Psychology's protections are unusually durable — but they're all attached to the license. A licensed clinician is about as protected as anyone in this index. An unlicensed graduate has none of it.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Writing up session notes	Reviewing an ambient draft
Administering and scoring assessments	Interpreting results that arrive scored
Screening at intake	Triaging cases that arrive pre-screened
Tracking outcomes manually	Reading continuous outcome data
The therapy itself	Unchanged

The last row is the important one. In psychology the automatable layer and the therapeutic layer are cleanly separable in a way they aren't in most professions.

Two caveats. Verification becomes a clinical responsibility — an inaccurate record in mental health care is a safety issue. And clinicians increasingly need to be able to discuss what a client

has been doing with a chatbot, which is a genuinely new competency.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Presence** — being reliably, attentively with another person. The core of the work and the least automatable thing in this index. 2. **Risk judgment** — recognizing when someone is in danger. High-stakes, low-precedent, and the reason accountability attaches to a human. 3. **Accountability** — carrying duty of care. 4. **Formulation** — building an explanation of why this person is struggling in this way. Genuinely novel every time. 5. **Discussing AI use with clients** — new, unavoidable, and barely taught yet.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: **curiosity and adaptability**. The specific tools — the ambient-notes system, the assessment platform, the outcome-tracking dashboard — will turn over many times across a career. The clinicians who compound are the ones who stay genuinely curious about the people in front of them and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of working they trained on. In a field where the automatable layer sits right beside the therapeutic one, that flexibility is itself a form of protection — and increasingly it's what services are hiring for: the capacity to keep learning, not the current toolset.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The licensed work is deeply valued by the people who do it. Practitioners describe it in terms of vocation rather than employment, and the reasons are consistent:

- **Depth of relationship** — few careers involve knowing people this well
- **Visible change over time** — the work produces results you can watch happen across months
- **Intellectual substance** — formulation is genuine problem-solving
- **Autonomy** — private practice is a realistic destination
- **Demand** — mental health need substantially exceeds provision in most systems

The practical case: low unemployment once licensed, flexible delivery including remote work, and a career that can be practiced well into later life.

What's genuinely hard about it

The length and the money. Six to eight years to licensure, much of it low-paid or unpaid supervised practice. **This is the real filter, and it is financial rather than academic.** It excludes people who cannot afford several years of low income in their twenties.

The emotional load is sustained rather than episodic. This is work with people in genuine distress, repeatedly, over decades. Vicarious trauma is a recognized occupational risk.

Not everyone gets better, and sitting with that is harder than students expect.

The undergraduate degree does not qualify you for anything clinical. Worth stating plainly because many students don't realize it until year three.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Psychology tends to suit people who:

- **Can be present without fixing.** The hardest and most important trait — much of therapy is tolerating someone else's distress without rushing to resolve it.
- **Are comfortable with slow progress**
- **Have genuine emotional stability,** since the work draws on it continuously
- **Are interested in people specifically,** rather than in the science of behavior in the abstract
- **Can sustain a long, expensive path**

It's harder for people who:

- **Need quick, visible results**
- **Are drawn to it primarily to understand their own experience** — common, understandable, and not on its own a durable foundation for a career
- **Cannot afford the training years,** which is a real constraint deserving an honest conversation

If some of that second list sounds like you, it isn't a reason to abandon the path — it's a reason to be clear-eyed about which version of it fits, and about whether the licensed years are ones you can sustain.

What else is moving this market

Demand exceeds supply almost everywhere, and workforce projections generally show psychology demand outpacing the supply of qualified practitioners.

The training bottleneck is funded placements, not applicants. Supervised-hours capacity limits how many people qualify.

Regulation is moving in the profession's favor, which is rare in this index.

And the honest counterweight: psychology is the fifth most popular undergraduate major, with no cap on numbers. The undergraduate market is crowded; the licensed market is not. Those are two different labor markets sharing a name. Which one you end up in is decided by whether you reach the license.

The number that frames where you are

Everything in this guide reduces to one question: will the whole path get completed?

Around 14% of psychology bachelor's degree holders go on to graduate study in psychology. A further 30% or so pursue graduate degrees in other fields. The remainder enter the general graduate market with a psychology degree.

That isn't a failure rate. Plenty of those graduates do well, and psychology is genuinely useful preparation for many things. But it means the modal outcome of a psychology degree is not clinical practice — it is a general graduate career informed by psychology.

Which is exactly why where you stand now matters so much:

- **If you're committed to the licensed path**, psychology is an excellent choice and the score of 3.5 is the relevant one — and the work now is protecting your place in that 14%.
- **If you're uncertain about graduate study**, the honest comparison isn't "psychology versus other degrees." It's "the general graduate market versus other degrees" — and there, the relevant score is 7.1. Naming that early is what lets you steer against it.

The question worth putting to your own department: what proportion of undergraduates reach licensed practice, and what are the rest doing five years out? The answer is usually smaller than people expect, and it tells you exactly how deliberately you need to move.

The AI-native advantage — what it actually looks like

The situation: clinical psychology is one of the few fields where AI arrives as *both* a workflow tool and a competing behavior. Being already in it, close to the work, is a real advantage here — you can build this fluency inside a placement, an assistant role or a first clinical job, which is exactly where it counts.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE PSYCHOLOGIST LOOKS LIKE

- 1. Verify.** Catching when an ambient session note misrepresents what happened. In mental health an inaccurate record is a safety issue.
- 2. Discuss AI use clinically.** Clients — especially younger ones — are already using chatbots for emotional support. A clinician who can ask about that without judgment, and work with what it surfaces, has a genuinely new and needed skill. Almost nobody is teaching it.
- 3. Understand the failure modes.** Knowing how these systems behave with someone in crisis, where they validate inappropriately, and why that matters clinically.
- 4. Contribute to policy.** Services are writing rules about AI in mental health care right now, and they need practitioner input.
- 5. Protect the relationship.** Being able to articulate to a client, a service or a regulator why a human is required — psychology's deepest protection, defended in words.

All five are available to you now — not after some future qualification. Turning them into concrete moves is the rest of this guide.

Where a psychology degree can take you later

Genuinely broad: clinical and counseling practice, school psychology, research and academia, organisational psychology, user research, health services, policy, HR and people roles, criminal justice, and teaching.

The pattern that runs through this index applies exactly: the further from licensed clinical practice, the higher the exposure. Organisational and HR-adjacent roles score 7.0 — good careers, ordinary exposure. That pattern is the compass for every choice below.

Repositioning from here

The program-selection stage is behind you. The useful questions now are different — and the good news bears repeating: **almost none of your exposure is fixed yet.** Psychology is a 3.6-point spread from 3.5 to 7.1, and where you land inside it is decided mostly by things still in front of you. Nearly all of them point the same way: toward the license.

If you're still in the degree or training

Three levers, in order of leverage.

1. The license is the whole game. The degree alone is the exposed end — it scores 7.1, and the general destinations beyond it (organizational / HR-adjacent 7.0, research / academic 6.5) aren't much better. The protected destinations — clinical psychologist (3.5), counselor / psychotherapist (3.9), school psychologist (4.0) — are reached only through graduate study and supervised hours. If you haven't committed to a licensed pathway, this is the single highest-leverage decision left. And ask your department, plainly, what proportion of undergraduates actually reach clinical training — it's the number that tells you how hard you need to push.

2. Research methods and statistics, while it's still free. This is what separates a psychology graduate from someone who has only read about psychology, and it's the spine of a competitive graduate application and of the research route (6.5). Treat it as core rather than a hurdle. Every quantitative and methods module you take now is far cheaper to acquire in the degree than to bolt on later, and it is the part of the undergraduate degree that graduate selectors actually weigh.

3. Assistant and support-worker experience, earlier than feels comfortable. The bottleneck for graduate applications isn't grades, it's relevant experience — and it doesn't have to wait. Helplines, support work, an assistant psychologist post, volunteering with people in distress: **that is the experience that separates the licensed tier from the general graduate market,** it's the on-ramp to the supervised hours, and it answers the fit question faster than anything else can.

If you've graduated and you're job-hunting

Here the title on the offer matters more than it looks, because the most common early destinations for a psychology graduate are also the most exposed.

- **The general graduate market and organizational / HR-adjacent roles are the 7.1 and 7.0.** They're where most psychology graduates land, and they're the exposed end at once. Taking one isn't fatal — but if the license is still the aim, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.

- **Aim at the licensed pathway.** An assistant psychologist or support-worker role that builds toward graduate training and supervised hours is worth more than a better-paid general graduate seat that leads nowhere near the license.
- **Consider the shorter licensed route.** Mental health nursing reaches licensed clinical practice in three to four years, scores 2.8, and is consistently overlooked by exactly the people drawn to the clinical work rather than the discipline.
- **Chase proximity to licensed practice.** A role with real contact with people in distress, under supervision, on a recognised path — even lower-paid, even at a smaller service — puts you years closer to the license than a comfortable seat that doesn't.

The AI-native move, from where you stand

You can't shortcut the training years, but you can be the graduate — or the trainee — who works with these tools rather than being surprised by them. The five capabilities above are all available right now, inside an assistant role, a placement or a first clinical job. The most powerful for someone already in it is the second: being able to discuss a client's AI use without judgment, and work with what it surfaces. Clients are already bringing chatbots into the room, and almost nobody is teaching clinicians how to handle it — so the person who can is carrying a genuinely new and needed skill, and it's one you can start developing this year, not after some future qualification.

The career-hunting checklist

The analysis tells you where the exposure is. This is what to do about it — the part that's actually in your hands. Most of the protection in psychology is built here, in these choices, rather than handed to you. The first list is for anyone still in the degree or training; the second is for the job hunt itself.

During the degree / training — build toward the license

- **Treat the license as the product, not the degree.** The protection in psychology lives at the licensed tier (clinical 3.5, counselling / psychotherapy 3.9, school psychology 4.0), not in the degree alone (7.1) or the general destinations beyond it (organizational / HR-adjacent 7.0). Aim every choice at licensed practice.
- **Ask your department about progression to licensure — and keep asking.** The proportion of undergraduates who reach clinical training is the number that matters and the one most rarely published.

- **Treat research methods and statistics as core, not a hurdle.** It's what separates a psychology graduate from someone who has read about psychology, and it's the spine of a competitive graduate application and the research route.
- **Secure assistant or support-worker experience early.** It's the bottleneck for graduate applications. Helplines, support work, volunteering — get real experience with people in distress, which also answers the fit question faster than anything else.
- **Get fluent with AI in mental health as a clinician, not a shortcut.** Both as a workflow tool — ambient notes, assessment scoring — and as something clients are already using. Learn to verify an ambient note and to discuss a client's chatbot use without judgment.
- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The tools will turn over repeatedly; the clinician who re-tools fastest, and stays genuinely curious about the people in front of them, compounds.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Properly vet the shorter licensed route — mental health nursing (three to four years, 2.8) — and the counselling, school-psychology and doctoral routes before committing. The order and cost of each differ enormously.

During the job hunt — aim for the license, don't just apply

- **Target the licensed pathway on purpose.** Assistant psychologist and support roles that build toward graduate training and supervised hours — not "any psychology-related role," which too often points at the general graduate market (7.1).
- **Read the title, not just the offer.** Organizational / HR-adjacent and general graduate roles (7.0, 7.1) are the exposed end. If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Don't grab a role just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. An employer still hiring the exposed rung may simply be behind the curve — and that's exactly the rung that gets cut first once they catch up. Availability can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.
- **Prefer proximity to licensed practice.** A lower-paid assistant role on the licensed pathway beats a better-paid general graduate seat that leads nowhere near the license.
- **Consider the shorter licensed route.** Mental health nursing reaches licensed clinical practice in three to four years, scores 2.8, and is consistently overlooked by exactly the people who would be good at it.
- **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** Whether they're building the job around these tools or waiting to be forced to tells you whether the seat grows or is quietly being hollowed out.

- **Weigh trajectory over starting salary.** The training years are financially thin; the answer to that is the license and where it leads, not chasing the highest first-year number into an exposed lane.

Go deeper — further reading

- **[The Labor Market for Recent College Graduates](#)** — Federal Reserve Bank of New York. Look up psychology's unemployment and underemployment rates against nursing and engineering. Free, quarterly, and from a central bank rather than a careers site.
- **[What Can You Do with a Bachelor's in Psychology?](#)** — the source of the 14% progression figure, and a realistic account of where a psychology bachelor's actually leads.
- **[Psychology and the Future: Two Decades of Graduates and Where They Work](#)** — North Carolina Department of Commerce. Twenty years of tracked outcomes for psychology graduates from a state system — unusually good longitudinal data, and a state government rather than an industry body.

The counterargument — read this one:

The strongest challenge to our licensed score isn't that AI will replace therapists. It's the opposite direction: that our 3.5 is **too optimistic**, because it measures the wrong thing.

Our framework asks whether a human must legally do the work. In therapy the answer is yes and is being reinforced by legislation. But if a meaningful share of people who would previously have sought professional help instead turn to a free, always-available chatbot, then the profession stays protected while its client base thins. Regulation protects the practitioner from substitution *inside* the system; it does nothing about substitution *before* someone enters the system.

Where we land: we think this is the most serious unresolved question in this index, and we've written it into the section on the trust factor rather than burying it here. We hold the score because our framework measures what it measures — and we state plainly that **a profession can be legally protected and still shrink**. We'll be watching referral volumes and waiting lists, and we'll report it if they move.

Bottom line

Psychology is two careers wearing one name — which is exactly why being already in it is not a problem. The decisive moves were always going to happen from here.

The licensed path is genuinely excellent — 3.5, protected by the highest trust rating in this index, comprehensive licensure, and regulation that is currently strengthening rather than eroding. Low unemployment, real demand, work that people describe as vocation.

The degree on its own is an ordinary graduate credential — 7.1, and around 86% of psychology graduates don't continue in the field.

So the useful advice isn't a verdict on the degree — it's a direction. The whole game is reaching the license, and the six-to-eight-year path, much of it low-paid, is what stands between the two ends of the table. Aim research methods, placements and assistant experience at graduate training. Steer the job hunt toward the licensed pathway and read the title, not just the offer. And build real AI fluency now, inside whatever role you're in, because that's a differentiator this field will increasingly reward.

And one option worth weighing if the pull is toward the clinical work rather than the discipline: mental health nursing reaches licensed practice in three to four years, scores 2.8, and is consistently overlooked by exactly the people who would be good at it.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one in it or a parent thinking it through, these are the conversations that move the needle now. Read "you" as whoever the decision is about.

Where you actually stand

1. Which destination are you currently pointed at — a licensed tier (clinical, counselling, school) or the general graduate market — and is it the one you'd choose on purpose? 2. Are you committed to graduate study and the supervised hours, or is that still an open question? Your honest answer decides which score is the relevant one — 3.5 or 7.1. 3. Do you have relevant experience with people in distress yet — an assistant role, support work, a helpline — or only coursework? If it's the latter, what's the nearest way to change that?

The move from here

4. What's the single most protected licensed pathway you could realistically aim for from where you are now, and what would make you a credible graduate applicant for it? 5. If you're still studying: how much research methods and statistics are you actually taking, and is there more you could add before it's no longer free? 6. If you're job-hunting: are you aiming at a role that builds toward the license, or applying to whatever's open? Name the three roles you're actually chasing.

The AI question, practically

7. Of the five capabilities — verify, discuss AI use clinically, understand the failure modes, contribute to policy, protect the relationship — which one could you start developing within the next few months? 8. Have clients or people you support already raised their chatbot use with you? How did you handle it — and how would you want to?

Testing it against reality

9. **The most valuable single action:** find a working therapist or clinical psychologist and ask what the path actually took, financially and personally, and whether they'd do it again. 10. **Have you looked at mental health nursing?** Three to four years to licensed clinical practice, scores 2.8. If the pull is toward the clinical work rather than the discipline, is there a reason not to?

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For psychology specifically, we've flagged that our framework measures whether a human must do the work, and cannot measure how many humans are needed — and that for this profession, the second question may matter more.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Psychology

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

1. The formula

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Risk} = & 0.35 \times \text{Automatability} \\ & + 0.15 \times \text{EntryErosion} \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Physical}) \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Trust}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Regulatory}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Judgment}) \end{aligned}$$

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent, where being wrong is costly?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

CLINICAL PSYCHOLOGIST (LICENSED) — 3.5 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.0	6.0	6.7	2.34
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.0	2.4	2.8	0.42
Physical / embodied	15%	6.5	6.5	6.5	0.53
Human trust / accountability	15%	9.5	9.5	9.5	0.07
Regulatory / licensing	10%	9.5	9.5	9.5	0.05
Judgment under novelty	10%	9.0	9.0	9.0	0.1
				Total	3.51 → 3.5

COUNSELOR / PSYCHOTHERAPIST (LICENSED) — 3.9 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.7	6.4	7.4	2.59
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.2	2.6	3.0	0.45
Physical / embodied	15%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.6
Human trust / accountability	15%	9.5	9.5	9.5	0.07
Regulatory / licensing	10%	9.2	9.2	9.2	0.08
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.8	8.8	8.8	0.12
				Total	3.92 → 3.9

SCHOOL PSYCHOLOGIST — 4.0 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.5	6.4	7.4	2.59
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.2	2.6	3.0	0.45
Physical / embodied	15%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.6
Human trust / accountability	15%	9.3	9.3	9.3	0.1
Regulatory / licensing	10%	9.0	9.0	9.0	0.1
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.15
				Total	4.0 → 4.0

RESEARCH / ACADEMIC PSYCHOLOGY — 6.5 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.8	6.0	7.4	2.59
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.0	5.6	6.2	0.93
Physical / embodied	15%	2.0	2.0	2.0	1.2
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	2.5	2.5	2.5	0.75
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.5	6.5	6.5	0.35
				Total	6.49 → 6.5

ORGANIZATIONAL / HR-ADJACENT ROLES — 7.0 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.0	6.4	7.6	2.66
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.5	6.2	6.8	1.02
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.0	5.0	5.0	0.75
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.5	1.5	1.5	0.85
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.45
				Total	7.0 → 7.0

DEGREE ONLY, NO FURTHER QUALIFICATION — 7.1 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.9	6.1	7.3	2.55
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.8	6.4	7.0	1.05
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.82
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.0	5.0	5.0	0.5
				Total	7.1 → 7.1

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Clinical psychologist (licensed)

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	5.0	2.0	0.75	2.8
2025	6.0	2.4	0.75	3.2
Fall 2026	6.7	2.8	0.75	3.5

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.59** and entry-path erosion **+0.12**, for a total of **+0.7** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.

- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.